



fitness race blending functional exercises and endurance sports, are no longer exclusive to elite Western athletes.

Although HYROX saw the light of day in Hamburg, Germany, in 2018, in India, it is about three months old. The first event took place in Mumbai in May this year. The second iteration, held on July 19 in New Delhi, brought together 2,600 fitness enthusiasts—an overwhelming 62 per cent increase in participation compared to the inaugural episode.

The Ironman also arrived on Indian shores in 2019, 41 years after the first edition in Hawaii. Held in Goa every year since then, barring 2020 and 2021 owing to COVID-19, it is organised in the 70.3 format. Also called the half-Ironman, the 70.3 gets its name due to the total miles one has to cover during said event: a

1.2-mile (1.9-km) swim, a 56-mile (90-km) bike ride, and a 13.1-mile (21.1-km) run. The 2024 chapter saw an uptick, with 1,200 participants getting flagged off compared to the previous year's 897 starters.

To be sure, these numbers are nowhere close to the attendance seen at the Mumbai Marathon, the largest of its kind and the only Gold-labelled World Athletics Road Race in India, but it's a start. One that Yoska, a technology-led health and wellness start-up that organises the Ironman and HYROX in India, can be proud of.

Neil D'Silva, the event producer of HYROX India and the race director of Ironman 70.3 India, believes the growing popularity of these multi-discipline endurance races is attributable to the ever-increasing disposable income of the lower and upper-middle class in the country.

Wellness wave: India's fitness journey is entering a new phase — where endurance is no longer elite, and transformation goes beyond the mirror. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

He tells *Sportstar*, "The general trajectory of people getting into the mindset of being fit has been on the rise, and that is obviously due to the progress we have made as a country. India is earning enough money and has enough time on its hands to also focus on health, which was not the case a few years back. That has been the primary driver for participation in the marathon and now the Ironman and HYROX. For a very long time, a marathon was the only end goal of fitness-related activities. That suddenly changed when the Ironman came to India, and people found